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A LONG LONG TIME AGO

SCENE 0: THUNDERSTORM DOWN SOUTH

Flashes of a thunderstorm - Flashes of a mother playing with her son - buildings and bird houses - - flashes of wind hitting the breeze upon the mountain fog - and flashes of a packed car and a vacation up north and to the east - from the barren west towards new england - flashes of a seaside beach town - flashes of a big thunderstorm - flashes of mom and dad getting gas - driving doing errands - flashes of Dallas setting up an weather device - flashes of a smile - flashes of a young boy in his mother's arms - flashes of a soft embrace - flashes of the hand on her shoulder from the warmth of her husband - flashes of chemo - flashes of weather instrument - flashes of experimental procedures in the garage and pointing it towards the sky - flashes of Mac helping him - flashes of the woods - flashes of green eyes in the tall grass - flashes of the dark grass - flashes of the mother coming back and running away from the dog - towards the light - flashes of a mother holding on to a bird house - sick - as she watches the birds flutter - she smiles - flashes of the darkness - flashes - of Dallas trying to shine lazars into the mirrors - and then the refractions into the eyes of the mom - but leaving the mom hopeless and flashes of dallas holding young mac alone in a hospital waiting room - of the tallgrass and green eyes that sparkle like fireflies.

SATURDAY

SCENE 1: EXT. WINDY SEASIDE ROAD - DAY

DALLAS (40s) and his son *MAC (10)* drive along a winding seaside road. The rugged coastline stretches beside them, with Atlantic waves crashing against the rocks. A storm brews in the distance, dark clouds gather on the horizon.

As they drive the radio is on and the newscaster is almost excited to announce that there is a storm coming and that we are about to enter hurricane season.

SCENE 2: EXT. NEW HOUSE - SOUTHERN CONNECTICUT COAST - DAY

Dallas signs papers on a clipboard handed to him by a MOVER. The Movers begin unloading boxes from the truck.

Nearby, a TV CAMERAMAN and a CAMERA CREW capture a REPORTER speaking into the camera. Mac watches from a distance, curious and uncertain about the commotion.

SCENE 3: EXT. NEW HOUSE - DRIVEWAY - DAY

Dallas and Mac unload various items from a bucket in the back of their sedan. Among the items are an unfinished bird feeder and gardening tools.

Dallas pauses, staring somberly at the bucket. His emotions overwhelm for a moment.

SCENE 4: INT. NEW HOUSE - MAC'S ROOM - DUSK

Mac stands by the window, gazing out at the dimming light. Fireflies flicker in the tall grass. As the wind sways the branches, the fireflies' lights resemble the glint of eyes peering from the darkness.

Mac glances up at the sky - a late autumn night, clear.

A whimpering sound echos from a distance.

SCENE 5: INT. KITCHEN - NIGHT

Dallas carefully plates an avocado, an onion, and a sliced lemon—meticulously into small pieces and then reassembled to appear untouched. His movements are deliberate, almost ritualistic.

Mac sets the coffee table and turns on the TV. He flips through channels until he finds the local weather report.

ON TV: The same REPORTER from earlier, standing outside their house, discusses the unpredictable weather this time of year.

REPORTER

As you can see behind me, new traffic is - we even have some new residents - despite the ominous weather forecast. Meteorologists are predicting an unusually severe storm system to hit our coast within the couple of weeks hours. That's right folks - we're in for a wild ride.

Dallas moves closer to the TV, his expression growing concerned as he listens to the report.

REPORTER

Residents are advised to always be ready in case of a such an emergency - have a plan - stock up on the basics - essentials and prepare for potential power outages. Stay tuned for further updates on this developing situation.

Mac's eyes drift back to the window, where the wind has picked up, rustling the tall grass outside.

SCENE 6: EXT. NEW HOUSE - NIGHT

Thunder rumbles in the distance, and the wind causes the storm approaches.

FADE OUT.

SUNDAY

SCENE 7: INT. CHURCH - MORNING

The PASTOR stands at the pulpit, addressing the congregation. The church is filled with attentive listeners, including DALLAS (40s) and MAC (10), sitting quietly in a pew.

PASTOR

We are going to look at a new passage from the book of Isaiah - on our teaching series - and ask why we and what they thought back then - and what we think now - and what is still true. Have people changed that much? During ancient times, Israelites would make sacrifices of all kinds--grain, animals, even blood. But today, we know that blood sacrifice is no longer required.

CUT TO:

SCENE 8: EXT. CHURCH FELLOWSHIP AREA - AFTERNOON

The church bustles with activity as congregates gather and plop iceberg lettuce on their plastic plates. *Dallas* and *Mac* stand awkwardly on line - progressing slowly.

A *FRIENDLY MAN* (50s), noticing their discomfort, approaches them with a welcoming smile.

FRIENDLY MAN

Hey there, - hey (hey) - dont worry - im not cutting the line ha - but i mean i will if you let me ha ha - i joke i joke where y'all from?

DALLAS

Indiana.

FRIENDLY MAN

Indiana, huh? Never been - Well, welcome - Where are you living now?

DALLAS

Branford.

The Friendly Man's face lights up.

FRIENDLY MAN

No way! I'm in Branford too! Names Dominic - Howdy - hey whose this big guy - yo Kid you meet my kids - Whats your name again ? Dallas what are you from texas (snarls) hey hey big listen - We have a BBQ going on tomorrow for the three day weekend - you got off work right? bonnie told me youre some professor at Yale - i got a cousin who works at Yale - yeah big time - full health benefits - yeah he works the library - truthfully i dont know what the hell he does ha ha - okay let's get you a plate big guy .

_Dallas nods politely, Dominic points toward a flyer hanging on the fridge near the coffee machine. It reads: "23rd Annual Branford Harvest Sea Festival."

DOMINIC

My friend Diego works there - some charity who knows
- we should go

Dallas listens politely, nodding along, but his attention drifts as the man continues to rattle on.

In the distance outside by the playground, *Makayla and Asher* hover around an object - *Makayla* looks around and signals *Asher* to put it in a backpack - *Mac* sees from the distance - but doesn't say anything.

SCENE 9: EXT. BRANFORD STREETS - EARLY EVENING

Dallas and *Mac* walk home from church. The journey is a bit of a hike. They pass through the tall beech grass, a little pizzeria, a small post office, a free library mail post, and a mix of nice homes with boats docked nearby--some pristine, others not so much.

SCENE 10: EXT. MAC AND DALLAS HOUSE - BUTTERFLY LANE

They continue past it all, into their corner of the world--a quiet cul-de-sac near a land preserve and a bird sanctuary.

They finally arrive home, exhausted, taking in the sight of their new house as the wind begins to pick up.

The two look around at the property - and the property looks back at them.

Dallas peers in the distance at a kind of torn outdoor shed - he lifts peers the door open - and looks past all of the cobwebs and overgrown marsh that has entered it - he flicks the light switch - nothing.

Mac runs in the backyard and checks out the mailbox - which is irregular and begins to open.

SCENE 11: INT. NEW HOUSE - MAC'S ROOM - NIGHT

Later that night, *Mac* looks out his bedroom window. The fireflies are out again, their soft glow dotting the landscape. The wind rustles the tall grass outside, making the fireflies flicker and blur.

As *Mac* focuses on the distance, the fireflies' lights begin to resemble eyes watching from the darkness, unsettling him.

MONDAY

SCENE 12: INT. SEDAN - MORNING

Dallas closes the garage door of a makeshift outdoor workshop.

DALLAS, holding his phone with the latest iOS, follows Google Maps as they drive through town in their old sedan. The car's engine hums steadily as they approach the school. *DALLAS* glances at *MAC* (10), who sits quietly in the passenger seat, a mix of nervousness and anticipation on his face.

DALLAS

Hope you have a good day.

Mac nods, gripping his backpack tightly as they pull up to the school.

SCENE 13: EXT. SCHOOL ENTRANCE - MORNING

Mac steps out of the sedan, looking up at the imposing structure of his new school. The sounds of chattering students and the ringing of the school bell fill the air. *Dallas* watches him from the car before driving off.

SCENE 14: INT. CLASSROOM - MORNING

Mac enters the classroom, glancing around nervously at the unfamiliar faces. He finds an empty seat and sits down, trying to blend in.

The *TEACHER*, a man in his early 30s, stands at the front of the room, beginning his introduction.

TEACHER

TEACHER

(Sheepishly) Hello everyone. Good morning, everyone.
Welcome to class - my name is Mr. ### and I am your
5th grade science teacher - .

(noticing a distracted student) Hey, you paying attention?

(continuing)

This semester, we'll be exploring the wonders world
of-weather patterns, the phases of the moon, and
count all of the ripples of the tides... We'll then
move on and examine different ways in which the
phases of the moon rile together. In a chasm of
solar gravity - moon beams. the tides work.

Mac listens intently, but his attention is soon drawn to the window. Outside, the sky is overcast, and a field of wetlands with tall grass stretches out beyond the schoolyard.

SCENE 15: EXT. SCHOOL YARD - AFTERNOON

Mac sees *ASHER* (10) from afar, accompanied by *MOLLY* (12), the same girl from church. *Molly* hands *Asher* a bag, and *Asher* discreetly puts it in his backpack. *Mac* watches the exchange, his curiosity piqued.

SCENE 16: INT. SEDAN - AFTERNOON

Dallas picks up Mac after school. As they drive home, they realize that Asher and MAKAYLA are their neighbors. The TALKATIVE NEIGHBOR from church approaches their car, greeting them enthusiastically.

DOMINIC TALKATIVE NEIGHBOR

My Lord Indiana! Check you out big guy! Hey, Indiana! Look at us - we're neighbors! These kids are neighbors! Small world, huh?

Makayla walks behind her father into frame and walks right up to Mac. a group of neighborhood kids approaches Mac, one of them, a GIRL (10), speaks up.

MAKAYLA

Did you see me give Asher that bag?

MAC

Yeah.

MAKAYLA

You Did?

MAC

Yeah.

Asher, looking sheepish, quickly walks away back to the house. Molly approaches Mac, looking him up and down.

MAKAYLA

Can I trust you?

MAC

Yeah.

Molly glances over at Dallas and the Talkative Neighbor, then back to Mac.

MAKAYLA

Ask your dad if it's okay for you to come over after dinner tonight. If so - I'll tell Asher and he'll meet you outside with a bike.

MAC

I have a bike.

Mac nods.

MAKAYLA

Good.

Makayla turns and walks away, disappearing into the crowd.

Mac looks over at his dad - who is still talking to Dominic - and then back to the retreating figure of Makayla.

SCENE 17: EXT. MOLLY'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Molly opens up the bag, revealing crab meat and bits of chicken in some tiny zip locks. She hands some to Mac, along with sticks and string. The kids spend the night trying to lure something out in the wetlands, but nothing happens. A thunderstorm begins to brew, and the wind howls around them.

Suddenly, Molly's MOTHER calls her home, and the kids quickly pack up.

SCENE 18: INT. NEW HOUSE - MAC'S ROOM - NIGHT

That night, Mac looks out his bedroom window. The thunderstorm rages outside, the wind shaking the trees and tall grass. The power flickers, then goes out. Mac stares into the darkness, his eyes wide as he hears a loud crash from outside.

He presses his face closer to the glass, trying to make out what caused the noise, but all he can see are the blurred, glowing fireflies--now resembling eyes watching him through the storm.

FADE OUT.

TUESDAY

SCENE 19: EXT. HOUSE - TUESDAY MORNING

The morning sun casts long shadows as DALLAS steps outside, carrying a trash bag. He walks towards the bins, inspecting them for any sign of raccoons - he looks a bit puzzled at the far distance of the grasslands that surround their home.

In the distance, MAC (10) sprints towards the mailbox, eager to grab the mail. As he opens the mailbox, he notices something unusual: a small burn mark on the ground. It's not large or round, but scattered and irregular.

Dallas notices Mac's hesitation and walks over, peering down at the mark.

Dallas frowns slightly but doesn't comment further. Mac collects the mail, and they head to the car.

Mac looks down - next to the lightning mark there is a single gemstone laying on the ground. Mac doesn't touch it - but goes into the car.

SCENE 20: INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

The classroom buzzes with chatter as the TEACHER begins the day's lesson.

TEACHER

For those who were up last night, some of you may have the faint clap of a heard a distant rolling thunder - but what causes that? What causes these phonemeonms that allow us to get wild throughout the night? *The teacher throws a book on the ground*

TEACHER

I'm talking about boom thunder! And how long does thunder make a sound after lightning? Wake up people these are life long anecdotes! Today, we'll be learning about lightning forms--phenomena that are particularly interesting here on the coast.

*_*As the teacher continues, Mac glances across the room at ASHER (10). The two exchange knowing looks.

SCENE 21: EXT. SCHOOL YARD - AFTERNOON

School has just let out, and students are pouring out of the building. Mac spots MAKAYLA (12) waiting near the edge of the playground. She walks up to him, a serious expression on her face.

MAKAYLA

Can I trust you?

MAC

Yeah.

Makayla looks around cautiously before speaking.

MAKAYLA

Do you know about history - secret professors - tales of promises of the old? A long time ago, there was a group of professors who started absecret society - they were from Yale but they lived in Branford - okay - anyway - They would search these exact coasts - for specific crustaceans that they would find on specific rocks, during a certain time of the season, which is now.

MAC

Why are you telling me this?

MAKAYLA

Because we have to be certain-- that we get the right bait.

MAC

Bait for what?

MAKAYLA

The creature.

SCENE 22: EXT. CORNER BEACH - DUSK

The golden light of the setting sun bathes the beach in a warm glow. *Makayla*, *Asher*, and *Mac* arrive with flashlights and ziplock bags. They begin collecting small crustaceans from the rocks, carefully placing them in the bags with a bit of seawater.

Makayla finds *Mac* alone and begins to talk to him.

MAC and *MAKAYLA* sit on a driftwood log, the silence between them heavy. The distant sound of waves fills the air.

MAKAYLA

(after a long silence)

What happened to your mom?

MAC

(speaking softly)

She died a long time ago. She got sick when I was two... and died when I was three.

MAKAYLA

That's cool - my mom too - *(pause)* - so Why did you move here?

MAC

My dad got a job at Yale.

MAKAYLA

Doing what?

MAC

I don't know - physics and nuclear stuff.

MAKAYLA

He doesn't talk much does he.

MAC

No

MAKAYLA

He see's things doesn't he? Things that arent there?

_Mac doesn't respond - a long break.

The atmosphere is tense. Strange, wild sounds echo in the distance, like coyotes letting loose - and howling from far - and then close.

ASHER

What was that?

The kids freeze, glancing around. MAKAYLA grabs out a small audio recorder that she has - and motions for the rest of the crew to stay silent - but after the second cry - without a word, they quickly gather their things and rush to their bikes.

SCENE 23: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Mac pedals home as fast as he can, the events of the evening still fresh in his mind. When he arrives, he sees Dallas outside, watching the bird feeder sway with the wind.

Without hesitation, Mac runs to him and gives him a hug.

Dallas turns toward his son. And for a moment embrace - whilst doing so - they both hear the strange sound together--carried on the wind from the direction of the beach. Dallas looks out into the darkness, his concern growing._

SCENE 24: INT. NEW HOUSE - DINING ROOM - NIGHT

Dallas and Mac sit down on their couch for dinner. Tension lingers, and they eat quietly. The distant sounds of the night mix with the clatter of utensils, adding to the growing sense of unease.

On the TV is the *WEATHERMAN* - talking about how some hurricane quickly making headway along the southern coast, and how it is hurricane season. He urges viewers to be on the lookout.

FADE OUT.

WEDNESDAY

SCENE 25A EXT. OUTSIDE MORNING

Dallas and Mac walk the neighbor's dog but it isn't going well. They walk it by a patch of grass - tall grass - and Dallas looks off into the distance - Mac watches his gaze - and soon does the Dog - the latter too now staring at the great nothingness among the tall grass.

SCENE 25: EXT. DRIVEWAY - EVENING

DALLAS and MAC drive to a neighbor's house for dinner. The radio plays in the background.

RADIO ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

And now for your evening weather forecast. Expect clear skies tonight with a slight breeze off the bay side. Perfect weather for the upcoming that Branford Sea Harvest Festival next week. Oh yeah - it should be good this year - get the kids - the get family - the whole family! Though right now the storm seems to be coming in - so you might want to stay indoors - but not too long - because the storm will pass and we should be good for the festival.

SCENE 26: INT. DOMINIC'S SCREENED BACKYARD DECK PARTY - EVENING

The setting sun bathes the backyard in a golden glow of fury. Laughter and sizzling sounds engulf the air as the neighbors mingle upon the backyard screened deck. DALLAS stands with DOMINIC, who's talking enthusiastically.

DOMINIC

(gesturing with a fork full of ziti)

Yeah, yeah, Hugo--my cousin--throws a big party every summer. You'd really like him-- he used to own a cosignment store out in branford but now he throws these parties - for charity you kno - . You and your boy - what's his name?

Cut To : Kids table:

MAC

Mac

JOCYLEN

Joculen (beat) nice to meet you - my mom said you and your dad are from minnesota?

MAC

No - we were from Michigian - but we moved around.

JOCYLEN

My mom said that your Dad and my dad work together

MAC

Whose your dad?

JOCYLEN

Rodney Roberts

MAC

What does he do?

JOCYLEN

He makes tools and stuff for the weather.

MAKAYLA

Your dad is absolute Legend - watch your mouth
Jocynen

MAC

Really?

ASHER

I like him

MAKAYLA

He invented the kaledoscope ****

MAC

Where is he?

JOCYLEN

He moved to Florida - i'm here now with my mom and
grandma.

MAC

How does my dad know him?

JOCYLEN

My dad says everyone should know your dad.

MAKAYLA

My grandfather was like that

Cut to: Adults Table

(Dominic takes a bite of ziti, then continues)

DOMINIC

My old man - God rest his soul - used to tell me -
Dominic - baby - get with the times - but he wasn't
around much - and I worked the bars - I always
respected what he did though - that with the weather
- I mean, who knows when the next storm might hit

_Dallas nods politely, but seems a bit overwhelmed by Dominic's energy. Mac stands nearby, quietly listening but not engaging, his eyes occasionally drifting to the edge of the backyard. In the far distance there appears to be an object

_MAKAYLA (12) approaches Dominic, hugging him quickly. She then steps back, looking over at Mac as she adjusts her backpack straps.

MAKAYLA

Dad, I'm heading to the back with the others. We'll be back in 20 minutes.

DOMINIC

20 minutes? What do you got to for 20 minutes?

MAKAYLA

I want to show them the fort

DOMINIC

Ooo the secret fort - - Makayla - when you going to show us the secret fort?

MAKAYLA

Yes, Dad.

_Makayla and the crew at the kids table - head toward the far end of the backyard. She disappears into the twilight, silhouetted against the setting sun.

_Dallas watches them leave, as if sensing something in the air, but doesn't say anything. Dominic resumes the animated conversation.

SCENE 27: EXT. MAKAYLA'S SECRET LAIR - LATE AFTERNOON

The deck party continues in the distance. Mac wanders alone near the far end of Makayla's backyard, which stretches to the edge of the coast.

Mac stands still, staring at the water. Waves crash against the rocks. He scans the grass, looking for mysterious eyes, then back to Makayla.

Suddenly, a faint whimper--like an animal in pain--echoes from the wilderness. Nautical sounds engulf him, heightening his fear. The grass rustles, but it's unclear if it's wind or something else.

Frightened, Mac steps back, ready to return to the party. But before he can leave, the kids table emerges from the fog--Makayla, Asher, and Jocylen. They move purposefully, faces serious.

_Makayla steps forward, focusing on Mac.

MAKAYLA

(firm, yet urgent)

Mac, give me that shovel.

Mac hesitates, then nods and grabs a nearby shovel. As he hands it over, Makayla turns to the group, her expression shifting to leadership.

MAKAYLA

You there Mac, Mac?

_Mac takes a short breath and grasps his shovel. He begins to dig and dig and dig - almost in anger - almost too fast.

MAKAYLA

Alright.

_The kids, led by Makayla, move deeper into the tall grass, toward the tallest grass where the coast drops off into the sea. The fog thickens, and the air grows colder.

SCENE 28: EXT. THE EDGE OF THE TALL GRASS THICKET

The crew hang around the tall grass as time moves slowly against the wind - against the branches of the tall grass.

_Makayla takes out a pack of hotdogs from Asher's backpack cooler and cleans it on a flat rock - Mac grabs the the shovel leaning against the outer wall of the wigwam - and Asher slowly brings the baitfish over and puts it in the bucket.

JOCYLEN

Makayla this is crazy

MAKAYLA

Yeah - you think?

JOCYLEN

Makayla

MAKAYLA

What's crazy about it?

JOCYLEN

Huh?

MAKAYLA

You said this was crazy - what's crazy about it - Mac get the shovel and dig a hole by the edge of the lawn - we call that the outpost - we're going to plant another camera - Asher - get the rope swing pulley and string the bags of bait. - - See what we do is tie these bad boys to that tree there - and let them swing -

JOCYLCEN

How do we know this isn't just some racoon getting its kicks oabout it?

_Mac and _Asher diligently set up cameras on the surronding trees - they hook cables up to a battery pack taped onto a wooden panel.

SCENE 29: EXT. MAKAYLA'S HIDEAWAY - LATE AFTERNOON

_The kids gather at their hideaway--a makeshift wigwam - fort hidden deep in Makayla's backyard old playground set - grass. Inside, houses a rudimentary surveillance system: several portable HDMI Monitors - run by a batterypank tied to a solar panel. Shovels and buckets and poles are propped up against rocks and driftwood, their screens glowing in the dim light. Cables stretch out towards to a jury-rigged power supply--a large battery bank cobbled together from old car batteries and solar chargers.

_ASHER fiddles with the wiring as he ensures each screen is properly connected. Makayla walks over and sits down in front of the monitors. Asher, Mac, and Jocylen behind her.

MAKAYLA

The creatures are likely to come out tonight - the tide.

_Mac looks out the cracks of the makeshift wigwam - through it he watches the tallgrass swaying in the wind.

JOCYLEN

How do you know that?

_They exchange glances.

MAC

What creatures?

ASHER

(setting up a camera)

The wind will pick up and push the smell out -

JOCYLEN

Out where?

ASHER

Out there.

Asher tests the camera pan into the Tall Grass

_Makayla watches Asher set up the final camera.

SCENE 30 - BACK AT THE WIGWAM HQ

MAKAYLA

Asher, the feed isn't working.

_Asher leans over, squinting at the screen.

_He scrolls through the tiny menu of the cheap digital camera, but the screen remains locked in the wrong shutter speed.

MAKAYLA

Just turn the night vision on - we can fix it on computer

_Mac watches Makayla - and off in the distance - he hears a little noise - that it seems like only he could hear - he looks out the at the darkening sky, a hint of worry in his voice.

MAKAYLA

Mac what is it?

_Makayla looks torn, glancing between the malfunctioning equipment and her friends.

MAKAYLA

But we haven't got the camera working yet. Haaaaaa - okay - I guess we have enough cameras - Asher go and record - make sure you are saving it as an mp4.

JOCYLEN

(standing up)

Makayla we ought to go back - its been more than 20 min

MAKAYLA

Go then Jocylen - we are right in the backyard - tell them we're fine - but go if you need to - go go go go go.

_Jocylen leaves the wigwam...

CUT TO: EXT. DOMINICS'S BACKYARD - NIGHT

_Reluctantly, they begin to gather their things. Makayla lingers, staring out at the tall grass with a mix of disappointment and determination.

_As they pack up their makeshift surveillance system, the wind picks up, rustling through the grass. For a moment, it almost sounds like whispers carried on the breeze.

SCENE 31: INT. DOMINICS DINING ROOM KITCHEN - EVENING

The kids return to the party. Mac approaches Dallas, who's standing alone in the hallway, looking at wall-mounted family portraits--photos of when the kids were little. He looks at his son and smiles.

DOMINIC

Where were you guys?

MAKAYLA

We were out in the backyard

DOMINIC

You out there cookin Lizards - you better watch yourself Makayla (jokin) I'm joking kid relax - (to Dallas) I gotta check that the girl - i vote yes for bush craft - but got to make sure she aint doing witch craft.

_Bonnie comes out with a big mashed potato plate of mashed potatoes.

DOMINIC

Alright - let's go - it's time for dinner.

SCENE 31A - DINNER TABLE WITH THE DOMINICS

The crew sit around a table filled with bbq fixings and corn. Makayla doesn't eat her food much - Mac and the children set silent.

DOMINIC

What's wrong with you guys? Eat. (beat) Mac - how are you liking it up here?

MAC

It's okay.

DOMINIC

You guys have Dr. Stover this year?

MAC

Yeah

DOMINICS

That old man - I used that have him too - he still talking about the weather and what not?

MAC

Yeah

DOMINIC

Funny guy funny guy - You that funny guy that Mr. Robertson says hello.

MAC

Okay.

DOMINIC

Dallas - you got this kid in CCD yet?

MAC

What is CCD?

JOCYLEN

Confraternity of the Christian Doctrine.

DOMINIC

Yeah baby - and they got the best snacks - right Makayla? Tell them - tell them - - Makayla likes to horde the snacks - -

MAKAYLA

You don't understand how I'm using them?

DOMINIC

Alright - you're right - you are right - sorry
darlin - - Makayla ain't be eating them no no .

Yeah - has Makayla been outside collecting bugs and
frogs and sticks and making science experiments
driving her old man's hair out - right Makayla...
Since she's been a kid Dallas - a kid! She used to
take little army men I would get for Asher and
freeze them. Asher - you remember?

ASHER

Yeah

DOMINIC

Oh these kids - these kids keep me young - right kids - you like your young
pop? Pop Pop Pop - Boom!

_Dallas smiles.

DOMINIC

So how do you find it all?

DALLAS

What's that?

DOMINIC

How do you find it - The town - the weather - you
know civic stuff - how do you find it all?

DALLAS

It's not bad.

SCENE 32 - EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Dallas and Mac walk home - and Dallas is looking at the sky at the ocean - at
the neighborhood - at the tall grass.

As they walk into their driveway - they notice a howl in the distance followed
by a series of howls and howls and slow whimpers. They go inside.

SCENE 33 - INT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Mac looks outside his window and sees a disturbance in the tall grass. In the
distance a small light glows and flickers. Mac takes a little flash light and

flickers back - and the light goes out. And then it doesn't go on again.

THURSDAY MORNING

SCENE 34: INT. HOUSE - MORNING

Dallas begins to go inside, the sound of the breeze from the Long Island Sound rustling through the trees. He pauses, looking out at the sky before stepping through the door. From the corner of his eye - he spots a burn mark near the mailbox.

Dallas walks over and stands over it for a good while.

Cut to : Dallas and Mac in the car - driving to school.

SCENE 35: INT. CLASSROOM - MORNING

The class is in class eseshion - Mac looks out in the distance and sees another weather reporter taking footage of some bush behind a chain linked fence.

The teacher an elderly woman - asks the class a question - and Mac is the first to answer.

TEACHER

Mac - what have you learned about the weather so far this year?

MAC

There are a bunch of things - we live in an atmosphere - and the atmosphere is made up of a bunch of different things - and the weather is what happens when the atmosphere changes. Different things happen when the atmosphere changes. Animals and plants and things act differently when the atmosphere changes. And we can predict the weather - but we can't predict everything.

TEACHER

Okay Mac - I see you.

TEACHER

Asher

ASHER

Yeah?

TEACHER

What do you think about the weather?

ASHER

I like it.

TEACHER

What makes you say that?

ASHER

I don't know - I just like it.

TEACHER

Can you elaborate?

ASHER

I don't know - I just like it.

SCENE 36: EXT. CHURCH PARKING LOT

MAKAYLA

Did you guys hear the coyotes last night?

ASHER

How many do you think there were?

MAKAYLA

Dozens - - Mac did you hear them?

_Mac looks around for the apparent dogs.

MAC

Yeah

MAKAYLA

That's all you say? Yeah?

Mac hesitates but then nods.

SCENE 37: INT. CHURCH YOUTH GROUP CLASSROOM - AFTERNOON

Mac looks around and notices that some of his classmates are also his Sunday School classmates. The *Youth Pastor* begins handing out papers on the topic of ancient Israelites and what we can learn from their mistaken ways of seeking atonement.

The group sit around in a circle and play basic board games - and getting to know you ice breakers.

MAKAYLA

Pastor Jerry - have you noticed what is going on with the Weather?

After the class, the *Youth Pastor* notices *Mac* sitting alone and goes over to console him.

SCENE 38: EXT. CHURCH PARKING LOT

Mac sits alone as the rest of the kids' parents pick them up from Youth Group. He watches everyone and their families go into their various mini vans.

The *Youth Pastor* notices *Mac* sitting alone and joins him on the stoop.

JERRY

Mac, you seem deep in thought. Can I sit?

MAC

Yeah.

JERRY

Is your Dad coming to pick you up?

MAC

Yeah.

JERRY

That's good - that's good. First week - new town - new school - how's it going?

MAC

Good.

JERRY

Ah - that's good...

A group of seagulls fly overhead.

JERRY

(CONT'D)

Yeah - I remember coming here from Georgia - wasn't used to these New England winters. But that was a

while ago.

Mac continues to look onward.

MAC

Do you think there are creatures in other worlds?

JERRY

What's that?

MAC

The handout you gave before - and the talk after -
you said that the

_ CAME FROM _

to serve God.

JERRY

I did - yes.

MAC

So are there still creatures in this world?

JERRY

Hmmm. Well, maybe you could think of the creatures
of the deep waters that we're still figuring out.
(MORE)

JERRY

(CONT'D)

I think it's easy for us to get hung up on the
logistics - - but if you think about it there are
still - - ancient things - things we don't
understand - we're discovering about dinosaurs and
whatnot.

MAC

That's not what I mean. Makayla was talking about
these creatures that she has been seeing in the tall
grass - and now her and Asher and me are taking
pictures of the tall grass.

JERRY

Makayla is interesting huh - she's come a long way
since her father died.

MAC

I thought it was her grandfather that died.

JERRY

Is that what she said?

Dallas approaches and walks outside. He goes up to Jerry and shakes his hand.

DALLAS

Sorry I was late - thank you -

Mac walks into the car.

SCENE 39: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

That night, *Mac* steps outside and sees *Dallas* grilling. The smoke from the grill rises and catches the light, casting eerie shadows. *Mac* looks beyond the borders of their property, his gaze fixated on the tall grass swaying in the breeze.

Dallas notices him staring and follows his gaze, looking at the tall grass as well.

SCENE 40: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Later, *Mac* walks back inside to find *Dallas* staring at the weather TV. *Dallas* notices *Mac* and gets up. The two sit together by the TV. Off in the distance - the wind pulls up.

SCENE 41: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

That night, as they prepare for bed, a strange sound echoes through the house. The wind begins to pick up, rattling the windows. *Dallas* looks out into the night, the tall grass swaying ominously.

SCENE 42: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Dallas steps outside into the thunderstorm to make sure everything is secure. The wind howls around him as he checks the perimeter, a sense of unease settling in.

FADE OUT.

FRIDAY

SCENE 43: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - MORNING

The next morning, the storm has passed, but the air is still heavy with the remnants of the previous night's events. *DALLAS* looks out the window and finds the seed from the bird feeder scattered about. *MAC* searches for the rocks they had collected earlier.

SCENE 44: INT. SCHOOL CLASSROOM - DAY

The *TEACHER* stands at the front of the class, addressing the students.

TEACHER

Not sure if you folks have been noticing, but the weather has been acting sporadic lately. Johnny, can you spell 'sporadic' for me?

SCENE 45: EXT. BEACH ROAD - SATURDAY MORNING

The crew goes wild with their bikes down the road, past the post office, riding along the tiny coastal sidewalks. The wind whips through their hair as they pedal furiously, their laughter carried away by the sea breeze.

SCENE 46: INT. SCHOOL MEDIA LAB - AFTERNOON

The crew--*MAKAYLA*, *MAC*, and a few other kids--gather around a computer. They stand over a software editor, DaVinci Resolve, going frame by frame through various camera footage, scanning for any sign of eyes or other mysterious figures. *MISTY* hands *MAKAYLA* another camera, and she inserts its SD card into the computer.

Nothing unusual comes up on the screen.

SATURDAY #2

SCENE 47: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - MORNING

DALLAS is outside, focused on building a bird feeder. He watches the way that the reflection of the glass holding the seed reflects off of it - and how it goes into the garage. He examines his creation, a little then turns his attention to a bucket filled with gardening supplies. Initially hesitant, he eventually begins tending to the garden.

MAC rummages through the bucket, discovering an old fishing wire and a ring. He fashions a makeshift ring toss game on a tree across from the tall grass.

Mac plays for a while, then retrieves his bike and rides off.

SCENE 48: EXT. MAKAYLA'S HOUSE - MORNING

Mac parks his bike outside Makayla and Asher's home. *DOMINIC*, the talkative neighbor, answers the door.

DOMINIC

Oh, what's up Mr. Mac - what's shaking my friend? How's your Dad doing?

MAC

He's okay.

DOMINIC

What's he up to these days?

MAC

Works mostly

DOMINIC

Tell him to call me sometime. You looking for Makayla?

MAC

Yea.

DOMINIC

Makaylaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaaa

Makayla comes running upstairs from the den to the kitchen - with camcorders, and various electronic equipment in hand she .

SCENE 49: INT. MAKAYLA'S DOWNSTAIRS DEN STUDY - DAY

The room is cluttered with bookcases of vinly and vhs - radios and dials - but beyond it lies a little beads that hang from the wall - as they enter between the dishwasher and the single cement window lays Makaylas inner headquarters. - She turns on a feed and it shows the remote locations outside - the feed shows the wigwam. covers, playhouses, and dust-covered blankets concealing

books and chests. *Makayla, Mac, and Asher* huddle around a dusty laptop with basic movie editing software.

There is a washer and dryer and various other household items.

MAKAYLA

(whispering)

I was thinking we could triangulate the places where we had our encounters and make a map - find a pattern and start to track.

Makayla fires open a redumnetary (sic) paint program on her computer.

MAKAYLA

Mac... Mac

MAC

Yeah?

MAKAYLA

Can I trust you?

Makayla retrieves an old, leather-bound journal from a shelf. She begins reading aloud from an entry dated 1925, describing her grandfather's encounter with strange creatures in the woods.

Inside the book there are various drawings of the creatures - Mac's eyes grow wide.

MAKAYLA

(reading)

"Wednesday - 79 degree farhienhite - 1925 - wind gust averages ____ - outside - near the coast - far off in the distance I stood with my father - and we both saw the stones..."

As Makayla continues reading, the wind outside picks up.

MAKAYLA

(determined, closing the journal)

We have to find out what happened next. If Grandpa saw them, then we can too. We just need to figure out what they want... before it's too late. I think they want the chicken on the stick.

MAC

I think I should go home.

MAKAYLA

What do you mean?

ASHER

It's getting windy.

MAC

I don't feel good.

MAKAYLA

Don't lie to me Mac.

The two look at each other for a good while.

MAKAYLA

Don't ever lie to me.

MAC

Okay - I want to go home because I don't think it is a good idea that we summon these creatures...

MAKAYLA

You really think that?

MAC

What do you mean?

MAKAYLA

Is that the real reason why you want to go home?

ASHER

Makayla - stop

MAC

I want to see my dad.

MAKAYLA

What do you think he's doing right now?

ASHER

Makayla...

MAC

I'm out of here.

_Mac gets up and walks out the door and grabs his bike and rides home.

SCENE 50: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Mac rides his bike home alone among the tall grass.

MAC

Okay - when do you want to do this?

MAKAYLA

We have to wait on the weather - for a true thunderstorm.

SCENE 51: EXT. MAC'S BIKE RIDE HOME

Mac rides his bike along the tall grass, scanning for eyes. He notices a dog in the distance acting strangely, barking at the tall grass. Mac speeds up.

SCENE 52: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - OUTSIDE GARAGE

Mac finds Dallas outside taking weather measurements. Dallas explains how it works.

In the distance, a camera crew is filming something in the tall grass. Mac, curious, walks over to investigate. He spots another gemstone on the ground but doesn't touch it.

SCENE 53: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - DINNER TIME

Mac and Dallas eat dinner while watching TV. News reports discuss the approaching hurricane and "hurricane season."

Mac looks out the window, searching for eyes in the tall grass. He sees a flicker in the night.

That night, as the wind howls, Mac's gaze wanders across the street to the tall grass.

SUNDAY #2

SCENE 54: INT. CHURCH SANCTUARY

The church is buzzing with talk of the town - apparently a very strange event happened to everything the night before.

Mac looks at different congregates hovering around a coffee pot as an older gentleman hands out welcome cards. On the screen there are announcements for the upcoming Harvest Festival - the church is going to be a part of it and run the kids crafts table - volunteers are needed.

Mac and Dallas walk into the pew and sit behind a baby that stares at Mac.
The piano begins.

PASTOR JERRY

Please find a seat - our call to worship this morning is from the book of
Isaiah - Chapter 52 verse 25.

The projector screen displays the verse.

Mac looks around for Makayla and Asher but they are not here this morning.

SCENE 55: EXT. CHURCH OUTSIDE FELLOWSHIP LUNCH

Mac approaches Jerry and asks him if he has seen Makayla or Asher.

MAC

I was with them yesterday.

PASTOR JERRY

They were supposed to help out with the nursery room - all good - just not
like their father to not bring them - okay - sorry - just wanted to make sure
they were okay.

SCENE 56: EXT. BEACH HOUSE

*Mac and Dallas approach their home from their walk. Mac runs over to the
mailbox.*

Mac looks around the neighbors' house but sees their car gone.

MONDAY #2

SCENE 57: INT. SCHOOL

*Mac checks the stones - they are still there. School begins and ends. The
teacher talks about the weather more. Asher and Mac eat silently during lunch.
Makayla's father takes them home.*

Mac goes home that night and sees Makayla sitting alone.

SCENE 58: EXT. MAKAYLA'S HOUSE

MAKAYLA

I saw the creature last night.

Mac's eyes widen.

MAKAYLA

It came.

Mac's eyes widen again.

MAKAYLA

Asher's in the hospital.

MAC

Really?

MAKAYLA

We were going to get the footage before it got dark - and as we were approaching the camera - He saw the creature too and he ran away and he broke his leg - I stood there and stood still... we were there until late - and I was tired so I asked my dad if I could stay home from school today and he said it was okay - he took off work himself - Asher's in the hospital and we're going to go over after we shower and visit him - he should be back tomorrow.

MAC

Have you talked to him?

No - not really - I told him not to talk about what we were doing back there - as the adults would think would get all worried and start a big investigation and ruin our plans before they begin.

MAC

What do you see?

MAKAYLA

I saw eyes in the distance... And then - and then I don't know what happened - it was like - I was dreaming for a second - but then I woke up and it was gone - and Asher was crying in the distance.

MAC

Did you look at the footage?

Makayla Smiles.

CUT TO

SCENE 59: INT. HALF-FINISHED BASEMENT COMPUTER ROOM

The crew look at a series of old CRT era laptops all haphazardly and hackerdly arranged - and then a big slow motion - and then nothing - and then Asher

crying - but a flash of light - and in the center as they zoom nothing - but as a filter is applied - some makeshift eyes appear.

The dad comes downstairs and tells Makayla that they have to go - Mac needs to go home.

CUT TO

SCENE 60: EXT. MAC HOUSE

Dallas is out in the front yard looking at the gemstones and then he looks at Mac - Mac looks back - the two walk inside and check the weather.

TUESDAY #2

SCENE 61: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - MORNING

School has been cancelled. DALLAS turns on the TV.

TV ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Due to the impending hurricane, all schools in the area will be closed today. The storm is expected to make landfall...

MAC looks out the window, seeing a bright sunny sky. MAKAYLA and ASHER arrive on bikes.

MAKAYLA

Can we use your sink?

SCENE 62: INT. MAC'S KITCHEN

DALLAS stands over the sink, washing dirt off potatoes. He moves aside as MAKAYLA storms in.

MAKAYLA takes out an old metal instrument and begins washing dirt off of it.

MAKAYLA

(rattling on) I have a plan. I think the creatures have landed. I believe they've come with the storm. Now, we're going to mark them.

DALLAS putters around, looking for a towel to dry his hands.

MAKAYLA hands MAC the wet instrument. DALLAS hands MAC a cloth.

MAKAYLA and DALLAS lock eyes. ASHER bumps into them, carrying a box of meat thermometers.

SCENE 63: EXT. MAC'S BACKYARD

MAKAYLA demonstrates to MAC, ASHER, and DALLAS how to plant a device in the ground.

MAKAYLA (V.O.)

Creatures, like animals, give off heat... These are set to pick up temperature changes in the ground.

MAKAYLA pulls out an electrical device. DALLAS picks it up, inspecting it.

ASHER

Does it work?

DALLAS looks concerned, takes it to his workshop.

MAKAYLA

He's going to fix it, right? I think that one works. He'll figure it out. Here's another. *(tosses a trail cam to MAC)* It's a trail cam. When we get notice of ground temperature changes, we'll know when to look for footage. Grade A stuff - they detect night vision and anything else.

MAC

Where do you want to hang them?

SCENE 64: EXT. MAC'S BACKYARD - THE TREE

MAC uses his fishing line kit to tie down a device.

SCENE 65: EXT. MAKAYLA'S BACKYARD

MAC hangs another deer cam. ASHER plants meat thermometers near the tall grass.

MAKAYLA (V.O.)

The creatures give off heat - just like any other creatures.

SCENE 66: EXT. NEIGHBORHOOD

The kids ride bikes. MAKAYLA scouts locations. ASHER and MAC ride together.

ASHER

Do you think there are really creatures in the tall grass?

MAC

(Looking at Asher) Do you?

ASHER

I think so. Makayla seems to think so, at least.

SCENE 67: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - DUSK

The children arrive. DALLAS comes out with the fixed device, handing it to MAKAYLA. They exchange looks. MAKAYLA and ASHER ride off.

MAC and DALLAS go inside silently. DALLAS resumes washing potatoes.

SCENE 68: INT. MAC'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

MAC stares at glow-in-the-dark stars on his ceiling, then at a picture of his mom.

A faint cry, like a wounded animal, is heard in the distance, then stops.

MAC looks out the window at the tall grass. He sees nothing at first, then spots eyes.

He retreats to bed, then looks out again. Nothing.

Another cry is heard, followed by a loud crash.

SCENE 69: INT. MAC'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

MAC stands at his bedroom window, peering out into the darkness. The moonlight casts eerie shadows across the backyard. From his vantage point, he can see the BURN MARKS on the ground, scattered near the tall grass, more numerous than before.

His eyes scan the dark horizon, searching. For the briefest moment, GLOWING EYES appear between the swaying grass. MAC's breath catches in his throat. He blinks, and the eyes are gone. Was it real, or just his imagination?

Another faint cry echoes in the distance, sending a shiver down MAC's spine. He leans closer to the window, pressing his forehead against the cool glass.

Suddenly, the motion-activated porch light flicks on, startling MAC. He sees DALLAS step out onto the porch, looking around with a concerned expression.

MAC quickly ducks away from the window, his heart racing. He climbs back into bed, pulling the covers up to his chin. As he lies there in the dark, he can't shake the feeling that something out there is watching them.

WEDNESDAY #2

AUTHOR'S NOTE

This scene is a bit of a mess - I'm not sure how to write it. - From Here it gets very GPT

That morning is a long one to school. Mac and Dallas are silent as they drive past the windy hills and seaside coast.

SCENE 70: INT. SCHOOL - KITCHEN

The school is buzzing with the news of the creatures. The kids are whispering and pointing at Mac and Dallas as they enter.

Mac and Dallas sit at a table with Makayla and Asher.

MAKAYLA

We have to do it tonight. You've heard the forecast.

MAC

I know.

ASHER

We're going to be stuck in this metal box with a bunch of dead batteries.

MAKAYLA

What?

ASHER

The thermometers - they're dead.

MAC

I know.

MAKAYLA

We're going to be stuck in this metal box with a bunch of dead batteries.

MAC

I know.

MAKAYLA

We have to do it tonight.

MAC

I know.

SCENE 71: INT. SCHOOL - SUBSTITUTUE TEACHER

The classroom is unusually quiet as Mac and Asher walk in. They notice a stranger standing at the front of the room, a SUBSTITUTE TEACHER, who is fumbling with the attendance sheet.

SUBSTITUTE TEACHER

(nervously)

Good morning, class. I'm Mr. Thompson, and I'll be your substitute teacher today.

The students exchange curious glances. Mac and Asher take their seats, whispering to each other.

The substitute teacher clears his throat, trying to gain the class's attention.

SUBSTITUTE TEACHER

Alright, let's get started. Today, we'll be continuing with your weather patterns lesson.

Mac and Asher exchange a look.

SCENE 72: INT. ASHER'S HOUSE - LATE AFTERNOON

Asher's house is filled with the sound of the storm approaching. The wind howls outside as Makayla arrives, carrying a backpack full of supplies. She knocks on the door, and Asher quickly lets her in.

ASHER

Did you bring everything?

MAKAYLA

Yeah, it's all here. We need to set up the trap before it gets any worse out there.

They move to the living room, where they spread out the contents of Makayla's backpack: ropes, stakes, and a few homemade devices.

ASHER

Are you sure this is going to work?

MAKAYLA

It has to. We don't have any other choice.

They work quickly, setting up the trap near the back door. The wind outside grows stronger, rattling the windows.

ASHER

What if the storm gets too bad?

MAKAYLA

Then we'll have to be extra careful. But we can't wait any longer. The creatures are coming, and we need to be ready.

Asher nods, determination in his eyes. They finish setting up the trap and double-check everything.

MAKAYLA

Alright, let's go over the plan one more time.

They huddle together, going over the details of their plan as the storm rages outside.

ASHER

We can do this.

MAKAYLA

We have to.

They share a determined look, ready to face whatever comes their way.

Dallas comes outside and sees what they are doing. Dallas steps outside, noticing the kids setting up the traps. He watches them for a moment, then silently approaches, his presence unnoticed at first.

Asher and Makayla are focused on their task, unaware of Dallas's approach. He quietly picks up a stake and a rope, examining their setup.

MAKAYLA

Make sure the ropes are tight. We can't afford any mistakes.

Asher nods, tightening a knot. Dallas steps in, securing another stake into the ground with practiced ease. The kids look up, surprised to see him there.

As the wind howls louder, Dallas checks the stability of their setup, making sure everything is in place. He hands Makayla a rope, and she ties it down, her confidence growing with his support.

The kids nod, their resolve strengthened by his presence. As the storm continues to rage, they prepare to face the creatures, knowing they have Dallas's silent support.

SCENE 73: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

The house is dark and Mac and Dallas have dinner. Mac begins to talk about the creatures.

MAC

Dad... Do you think this is all real?

DALLAS

It could be.

MAC

Do you think we're ready?

DALLAS

I think we'll catch something.

MAC

What if we don't?

DALLAS

Then we'll won't.

MAC

Dad... Have you seen the eyes?

Dallas pauses, his expression serious. He looks at Mac, considering his words carefully.

DALLAS

There is something out there.

Mac's eyes widen, a mix of fear and curiosity.

MAC

What do you think they are?

DALLAS

Something we might have to address...

Mac nods, feeling a sense of reassurance from his father's words. The bond between them strengthens as they prepare for the unknown.

CUT TO

SCENE 74: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

_Dallas and Mac go into overdrive mode - preparing the house. They board up the windows and the stakes.

TV REPORTER (V.O.)

Evaucations are underway in the area - but are limited in scope focusing on the northen regions - for the southern regions - it is advise that people stay in their homes and board up any long - head for a basement.

Mac and Dallas sit in the living room, the glow of the TV casting shadows on their faces. Suddenly, Mac's phone rings. He looks at the screen and sees it's a FaceTime call from Makayla.

MAKAYLA

Mac?

MAC

Makayla?

MAKAYLA

We're ready.

As Dallas and Mac watch the tv - Dalls looks up at his book shelf - and takes out a box that he had eariler - and opens it - and takes out a mirror - and hands it to Mac.

MAC

What's this?

DALLAS

It's a mirror.

MAC

What do we do with it?